5.17 Selection Criteria

Selection criteria

Some application processes require you to respond to **selection criteria**. This means that applicants need to provide more information in their **application letters** or **expressions of interest** than what is contained in their résumés.

Applicants are being asked to demonstrate or 'prove' what they are saying on their CVs. The 'responses' help show the likelihood of an applicant's ability to fulfil the requirements of the specific job.

You are more likely to encounter **formal selection criteria** for higher-level, career-focused positions.

However, **informal selection criteria** are also being increasingly used due to the switch to online applications. Many e-applicants are applying for jobs that they are not qualified for by simply attaching their CVs as part of the online process.

Selection criteria enable employers to 'cull' prospective applicants quickly and eliminate serial applicants who are not suited to that job.

If an application asks you to address specific selection criteria (such as a list of questions) then the employer (or agency) is using a formal selection criteria process.

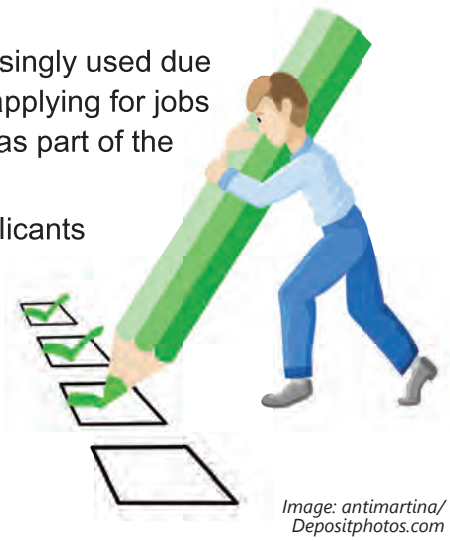

Image: antimartina/ Depositphotos.com

Informal criteria for selection

All positions are filled using a pre-determined set of criteria to guide the selection of applicants. These are the qualities the hirer is looking for in a suitable applicant for the job. For **entry-level positions**, these criteria for selection might include an applicant's:

- ✓ education level
- ✓ vocational qualifications
- ✓ general skills and abilities such as punctuality and reliability, communication and numerical skills
- ✓ employability skills and transferable skills
- ✓ general experience and skills
- ✓ industry-specific experience and skills
- ✓ licenses and industry-specific certifications
- ✓ practical or technical skills
- ✓ safe use of equipment, machinery and work-related technologies
- ✓ demonstrated evidence of successful teamwork
- ✓ community participation and involvement
- ✓ leadership experience
- ✓ health and fitness (where applicable for the role)
- ✓ age (where applicable for the role)
- ✓ understanding of the roles and responsibilities of the job
- ✓ understanding of the industry,
- ✓ and other criteria upon which an applicant might be judged as suitable for the specific role, that workplace and that organisation.

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

Informal selection criteria 5H

Sometimes we can learn more about unfamiliar processes by helping others. In pairs, develop **responses** for each of these **selection criteria questions**. Add 2 more.

Informal criteria	Me now...	What do I need to do?
education level		
vocational qualifications		
general skills & abilities		
employability skills and transferable skills		
general experience and skills		
industry-specific experience and skills		
licenses & industry-specific certifications		
practical or technical skills		
safe use of equipment & technologies		
evidence of successful teamwork		
community participation		
leadership experience		
health and fitness (if relevant)		
age (if relevant)		
understanding the roles of the job		
understanding of the industry		

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

5.19 Selection Criteria

Common selection criteria

Selection criteria guide the recruitment and selection process. There are common selection criteria that are used for nearly all job application situations. In most cases, these will reflect:

- ⇨ the type of **organisation**, i.e. mission, values, goals, operations and culture,
- ⇨ the type of **job/position** being filled, i.e. job description, and
- ⇨ the type of **person** being sought, i.e. to suit the workplace culture.

Selection criteria try to elicit responses that show the interrelationship between an applicant's **generic skills**, **employability skills** and **industry-specific skills**.

From here on, we will refer to these informal criteria for selection as 'selection criteria' rather than that more formal definition, as you are more likely to experience these examples of selection criteria at this stage of your career pathway.

Common 'Selection Criteria'

Ability to communicate effectively.

Reliability and punctuality.

Responsibility and leadership experiences.

Experience working in, or being part of a successful team.

Demonstrable industry-related experience.

Ability to work safely and to protect the safety of others.

Well-developed customer/client service skills.

Skills with occupational and industry-specific technologies and devices.

Image: marcinmaslowski/ Depositphotos.com

Entry-level generic skills

Before an employer will consider you for a role, they will generally expect you to be able to prove that you can deliver on these 'Big 10' entry-level generic skills. So, how will you communicate and 'prove' these in an application or an interview?

1. **Punctuality**
2. **Literacy**
3. **Numeracy**
4. **Teamwork**
5. **Communication**
6. **Following instructions**
7. **Technological competence**
8. **Health and fitness**
9. **Working safely**
10. **Ability to accept responsibility.**

Employability skills

And don't forget about your CEM employability skills. How will you best communicate and 'prove' these in an application or an interview?

- ⇨ **Communication**
- ⇨ **Time management**
- ⇨ **Digital literacy**
- ⇨ **Problem-solving**
- ⇨ **Teamwork**
- ⇨ **Critical thinking**

Industry-specific skills

And finally, which applied examples could you use to communicate the industry-specific skills you have developed?

A few crossover examples in each of the employability skills areas is a good start.

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

Common selection criteria 5I

1. Rephrase the 8 'Common Selection Criteria' on p.126 into **how** they **might** be **asked** in a **job interview** as **questions**. (Your teacher can help if you need it.)
2. How would **you respond** to **each** of these **questions**?

You will need to **relate** some of your answers to a **specific industry** and **job** in which you might be interested.

Question	Answer
1.	
2.	
3.	
4.	
5.	
6.	
7.	
8.	

Applied

a. Research job opportunities for a position you are interested in now, and/or one that matches your future career pathways goals. Find out and document the selection criteria for these positions.

b. Explain whether these selection criteria are general (informal), or more specific to the type of occupation and industry.

c. Do you meet these selection criteria? Why so, or why not?

d. What might you have to do to skill-up so that you can satisfy selection criteria in the future? Get advice.

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

5.21 Selection Criteria

Addressing selection criteria

i. SAO Technique

One method to address selection criteria and/or interview questions is to use the SAO technique. This involves treating all questions or criteria as a 3-part process, and developing or providing responses in three stages.

1. Situation: Describe a task or situation where you demonstrated work-related or transferable competencies and skills.

2. Action: Give examples of what you did and how you did this. Identify resources used such as, other people, equipment, etc..

3. Outcome: Summarise the outcome; was it successful and why; or was it unsuccessful and if so, how would you improve?

So consider how you would use SAO if you were asked to, "Describe how you have worked effectively in a team."

Using SAO

Have a look at the SAO example below and discuss this as a class. What would you have done in that application situation?

What do you reckon? Has this applicant clearly described the situation that happened, explained the action, and then reported on the outcome?

Image: william87/ Depositphotos.com

Applying SAO

Question: 'Describe a time where you had to use initiative, and explain what you did.'

Situation

Applicant: "Earlier this year I was working part-time as a waiter at a busy café during a long weekend. We were short-staffed, and a large group arrived unexpectedly without a booking."

Action

The 'reader' would now be thinking, '...So, what did you do?'

Applicant: "I quickly checked the floorplan and saw that two small tables could be rearranged to fit the group. I grabbed menus, set the table, and let the group know we'd get them seated shortly. While doing this, I gave the barista and kitchen staff a heads-up so they wouldn't be caught off guard."

Outcome

At this time, the 'reader' would now want to know: '...What happened?'

Applicant: "The group appreciated not being turned away, and my supervisor thanked me for thinking on my feet. We managed to serve them efficiently, and they ended up leaving a generous tip and a positive review online. My boss later mentioned that it showed good problem-solving and customer service under pressure."

Image: ikostudio/ Depositphotos.com

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

ii. Can you STAR?

The STAR technique is another method for answering application or interview questions. The STAR technique is more suitable for jobs that require you to communicate a proven ability to demonstrate how you have achieved **specific tasks** and **competencies** in work-related situations.

Given this, it can be a very useful tool to help you succeed in applications and interviews where you have specific task experience related to the role you are applying for. However, it is very similar to SAO, it just adds one more step.

1. Situation - Describe a situation where you demonstrated competencies and skills.

2. Task - What was your specific role in this situation?

3. Actions - What did you do? How did you do this? What resources did you use?

4. Results - What did you achieve? What was the end result?

So from the SAO example, '**Situation**' would be, "Earlier this year I was working part-time as a waiter at a busy café during a long weekend..." and '**Task**' would be, "...We were short-staffed, and a large group arrived unexpectedly without a booking."

The '**Actions**' would be: "I quickly checked the floorplan and saw that two small tables could be rearranged..." and so on. And '**Results**' are just the same as SAO's 'Outcome', with any evidence or measurable achievement that can add weight to the example

iii. CAR

CAR is similar to SAO, but it is more likely to be used in **professional** settings. It suits situations where you're discussing a challenge or context that might not be purely task-based (e.g. solving a problem, managing conflict, dealing with change, making a strategic decision, etc.).

1. Context (or challenge) e.g. While volunteering at a local opp shop, I noticed that the storage area was cluttered and made it hard to find donated items.

2. Action e.g. I spoke with the manager and suggested a system using colour-coded labels, and scheduled a working bee to reorganise with other volunteers.

3. Result e.g. The system reduced time spent finding items by nearly half, and the manager said it helped increase sales.

Generally, CAR might be more suited for mature, experienced applicants, professional roles, people-focused responsibility roles, or for applicants applying for apprenticeships or traineeships who want to show technical problem-solving or personal resilience. CAR might also be more likely to be used in interviews rather than applications.

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.

5.23 Selection Criteria

SAO, STAR or CAR?

So SAO, STAR or CAR? Which one? Well they are basically the same - STAR is just broken down a bit more. SAO and CAR are cousins but may be applied in different types of roles e.g. entry-level vs experienced. What is important is that you are familiar with the terminology of what you are being asked, just in case you have to use one of these techniques in an application or interview.

e.g. Question: "Give an example of when you solved a problem."

SAO version

Situation: While working at a café during a busy Saturday shift, the EFTPOS machine stopped working.

Action: I told the manager, put up a "Cash Only" sign, and helped direct customers to the nearest ATM. I stayed calm and kept everyone informed, while helping staff take manual orders.

Outcome: Most customers appreciated being kept in the loop. The manager thanked me and mentioned it again in our next team meeting.

STAR version

Situation: While working a busy Saturday morning shift at a café, our EFTPOS machine suddenly stopped working.

Task: As the person working front counter, I needed to keep serving customers efficiently, while finding a solution so that the café didn't lose sales or cause confusion.

Action: I let the manager know straight away, then put up a "Cash Only" sign so customers would understand the situation. I also offered to direct people to the nearest ATM and helped the kitchen staff take manual orders so things stayed organised.

Result: Even though it was a stressful situation, customers stayed calm and were understanding because we communicated well. The manager thanked me for taking initiative, and I was praised during our next team meeting.

CAR version

Context: At my part-time café job, the EFTPOS machine broke down during a busy morning shift.

Action: I immediately informed the manager, helped set up a plan to take cash-only payments, and made sure customers knew what was happening. I also supported the team with manual tracking of orders.

Result: Everything kept running smoothly despite the issue, and I was recognised for handling the situation calmly and responsibly.

5J Responding to job ads

Look at one of the following **job ads** and **summarise** the **main information** that you need to know so as to apply. You can do this in writing or verbally.

Now swap your notes with another student. See if they can use them to **format** the **information** you have supplied, into a **response** to the job ad. Apply techniques to address the **potential selection criteria questions**.

Applied

Find current job advertisements for positions for occupations that match your career pathways goals. Report back to interested peers and/or to the class.

a. Where will you search? What key words will you use?

b. How many jobs did your search turn up? Were these suitable for you?

c. Summarise the most relevant job ads you found.

d. What would you need to do to apply, either now, or in the future?

Licensed for use by Emmanuel Catholic College
CEM G12: Careers and Employability - e-master
Written by Michael Carolan. Copyright © 2025 DELIVER Educational Consulting and its licensors. All rights reserved.